

Chipotle: make digital growth work in the restaurant

Member	Role (proposed team split)
Alifya Saify	Roadmap Sequencer
Disha Reddy	Governance Designer
Rishit Mathur	Dashboard Designer
Shima Kananiazari	Dashboard Designer / integration and review coordination

Proposal and rationale

Bottom line. A better app does not help much if the food is late. We connect ordering, kitchen work and Rewards so a problem in one does not slow the others. We propose eight initiatives in three phases, seven governance decisions with one accountable owner each, and gates that stop expansion when a pilot misses its checks.

Phase	Timing	What happens	What must be true to move on
Crawl Foundation	Q1 to Q3	I1 ordering, I2 digital make line and I3 Rewards data are built in parallel.	Orders routed correctly (99.5%), crews ready (90%), usable profiles (99.5%).
Walk Deployment	Q4 to Q6	I4 delivery in 20 restaurants, I5 Chipotlane at 5 sites, I6 Rewards offer for 50,000 members.	95% on-time delivery, 3-minute lane handoff, 2-point repeat-visit lift.
Run Scale	Q7 to Q8+	I7 fulfillment and I8 Rewards offers expand to approved US groups.	Separate approvals per channel; staffing rules, discount limits and offer throttling in place.

Case evidence. Chipotle's 2018 to 2023 annual reports and its 2024 proxy statement. These are historical sources; the sequence, pilot sizes, targets and owners are our proposal, and Q1 to Q8 are project quarters, not calendar dates.

Governance. CCTO owns interfaces, data and partners (D2, D3, D5); CFAO funding (D1); CEO prioritization (D4); COO launch readiness (D6); CBO Rewards offers (D7).

Dashboard and team note. The one-page dashboard is a separate file, qbr-dashboard.html, and uses made-up Q7 values. The brief lists three roles for four members, so Rishit and Shima share dashboard work; this split still needs the team's agreement.

Build the basics, test them, then expand

Initiative	Crawl: Foundation			Walk: Deployment			Run: Scale	
	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8+
I1 Digital ordering upgrade	Q1 to Q3							
I2 Digital make-line setup	Q1 to Q3							
I3 Chipotle Rewards data setup	Q1 to Q3							
I4 Delivery integration pilot				Q4 to Q5: needs I1, I2				
I5 Chipotlane pilot				Q4 to Q6: needs I1, I2				
I6 Personalized Rewards pilot				Q4 to Q6: needs I1, I3				
I7 Digital fulfillment rollout							Q7 to Q8+: scales I4, I5	
I8 Personalized Rewards rollout							Q7 to Q8+: scales I6	

Dashed red lines mark gate G1 (end of Q3) and gate G2 (end of Q6); the checks are on page 4. Crawl initiatives run in parallel and none depends on another.

Dependency annotations

- I1 Ordering upgrade → I4 Delivery pilot:** enables routing and reconciling delivery orders without duplicate tickets.
- I2 Make-line setup → I4 Delivery pilot:** enables kitchen capacity and a named driver-handoff step.
- I1 Ordering upgrade → I5 Chipotlane pilot:** enables linking a prepaid order to the correct pickup restaurant and guest.
- I2 Make-line setup → I5 Chipotlane pilot:** enables a separate prep queue and trained pickup crews.
- I1 Ordering upgrade → I6 Rewards pilot:** enables recording offer redemption and the follow-up purchase.
- I3 Rewards data setup → I6 Rewards pilot:** enables customer groups with permission and purchase history.
- I4 Delivery pilot → I7 Fulfillment rollout:** enables the tested delivery process and partner economics.
- I5 Chipotlane pilot → I7 Fulfillment rollout:** enables the tested Chipotlane layout, staffing and handoff rules.
- I6 Rewards pilot → I8 Rewards rollout:** enables a measured offer effect and a reusable control-group design.

02 / SCOPE & CHECKPOINTS

What each initiative has to deliver

Crawl: Foundation (Q1 to Q3). No Crawl initiative depends on another; each uses existing systems.

Initiative	Quarters	Capability created for Walk	Exit check
I1 Digital ordering upgrade	Q1 to Q3	One order ID from payment to kitchen receipt; reliable routing. Uses the existing point-of-sale system.	99.5% of orders reach the right place for four weeks; no duplicate charges.
I2 Digital make-line setup	Q1 to Q3	A separate prep line for digital orders and crews trained to make, check and hand over. Uses point-of-sale test tickets.	90% of sampled crew pass a practice shift.
I3 Chipotle Rewards data setup	Q1 to Q3	Member IDs linked to purchases and permission to send offers. Uses existing sign-up and purchase records.	99.5% of sampled profiles usable; no-permission records excluded.

Walk: Deployment (Q4 to Q6). Limited pilots; each names its Crawl dependency.

Initiative	Quarters	Crawl dependency	Limited scope	Measurable readiness outcome
I4 Delivery integration pilot	Q4 to Q5	I1 and I2	20 US restaurants, one partner.	95% of orders ready by the promised pickup time for four weeks.
I5 Chipotlane pilot	Q4 to Q6	I1 and I2	Five suitable US sites.	90% of guests served within 3 minutes for four weeks.
I6 Personalized Rewards pilot	Q4 to Q6	I3 and I1	One offer, 50,000 members; half get it, half are a holdout.	At least +2 points in 30-day repeat visits (95% interval above zero).

Run: Scale (Q7 to Q8+). Each rollout names the Walk initiative it scales.

Initiative	Quarters	Walk initiative scaled	Full-scale scope	Organizational change required
I7 Digital fulfillment rollout	Q7 to Q8+	I4 (delivery) and I5 (Chipotlane). Each channel needs its own pass.	US restaurants the service can reach; suitable new or converted Chipotlane sites. National operating plan by Q8.	Restaurant leaders adopt the same staffing and pickup rules; COO signs each group's release; delivery partners checked weekly.
I8 Personalized Rewards rollout	Q7 to Q8+	I6.	All suitable US member groups, with no-offer comparison groups kept.	Brand reviews offers weekly; Finance sets discount limits; Operations can reduce offers when restaurants are busy.

The reasoning behind the phases

Crawl: get the basics working	Walk: try it small first	Run: grow what passed
Orders must reach the right kitchen, staff must know how to handle them, and Rewards records must be trustworthy. If these are broken, a pilot mostly shows setup problems, not whether the idea works. The three jobs run in parallel because each uses existing records and systems.	One good week is not evidence. Each pilot tests a different risk: drivers collect orders on time, the lane queue moves quickly, and an offer brings people back compared with a no-offer group. Small pilots make problems easier to find and fix.	A good delivery result does not prove a lane is ready, so approvals stay separate. A lane problem stops new lane openings, not delivery restaurants that meet their own checks. If performance drops, the next group is paused and fixed first.

Dependency test. Without I1, pilot orders cannot be routed and measured. Without I2, added digital demand competes for an untested prep process. Without I3, a targeted offer has no usable records or permission to contact.

Gates that stop expansion

G1, end of Q3. Accept only what a pilot needs: I1 routes correctly with no duplicate charges, I2 crews are ready, I3 profiles are usable and records without permission are excluded. Crawl takes nine months; quarter ranges are planning assumptions, and a missed gate moves the next start date.

G2, end of Q6 and before each new group. Check the pilot result, positive earnings after direct costs (delivery fees included), food-safety controls and staffing. I7 needs separate delivery and Chipotle approvals; I8 needs a positive offer result and permission to contact.

System and process choices

Keep one order ID across checkout, kitchen receipt and pickup. Use shared interfaces rather than restaurant-by-restaurant integrations. Keep Rewards identity and permissions consistent across campaigns. In the restaurant, separate digital prep from the front counter and give one person responsibility for the final order check. These are our proposed design choices; the public reports do not publish Chipotle's internal systems.

What the company reported, and what we added

Source	Document and section	Supports
S1	Chipotle 2018 Form 10-K, Item 1: Guest Experience and Operations; Innovation. Read source	I1, I5: mobile ordering, digital payments, Chipotlanes
S2	Chipotle 2019 Annual Report, p. 5: Innovation and Marketing (PDF p. 7). Read source	I2, I3, I6: digital make lines, Rewards launch, individual-level marketing
S3	Chipotle 2020 Form 10-K, Item 1: Digital Business. Read source	I4, I5, I7: third-party delivery, digital make lines, Chipotlanes
S4	Chipotle 2021 Form 10-K, p. 21: 2021 Financial Highlights. Read source	I6, I8: June 2021 redemption choices and personalized offers
S5	Chipotle 2023 Annual Report, pp. 5 and 9: Digital Business and risks (PDF pp. 7 and 11). Read source	I1, I7, I8: app improvements, delivery, Chipotlanes, cost and service risks
S6	Chipotle 2024 Proxy Statement, pp. 51 to 52: Executive Officers (PDF pp. 55 to 56). Read source	RACI role titles as of April 1, 2024

Limits of the case

The reports are historical and do not establish our order, pilot sizes, targets, budget, internal system design or approval matrix; these are our proposals. We split broader company programs into setup, pilot and rollout packages so dependencies can be tested. Higher digital sales alone would not show whether an offer or pickup lane caused a change, so we compare customers who got an offer with those who did not and check service times and costs. We do not claim Chipotle used this sequence.

The one-page dashboard is a separate file, qbr-dashboard.html; this PDF contains the roadmap, RACI and supporting notes.